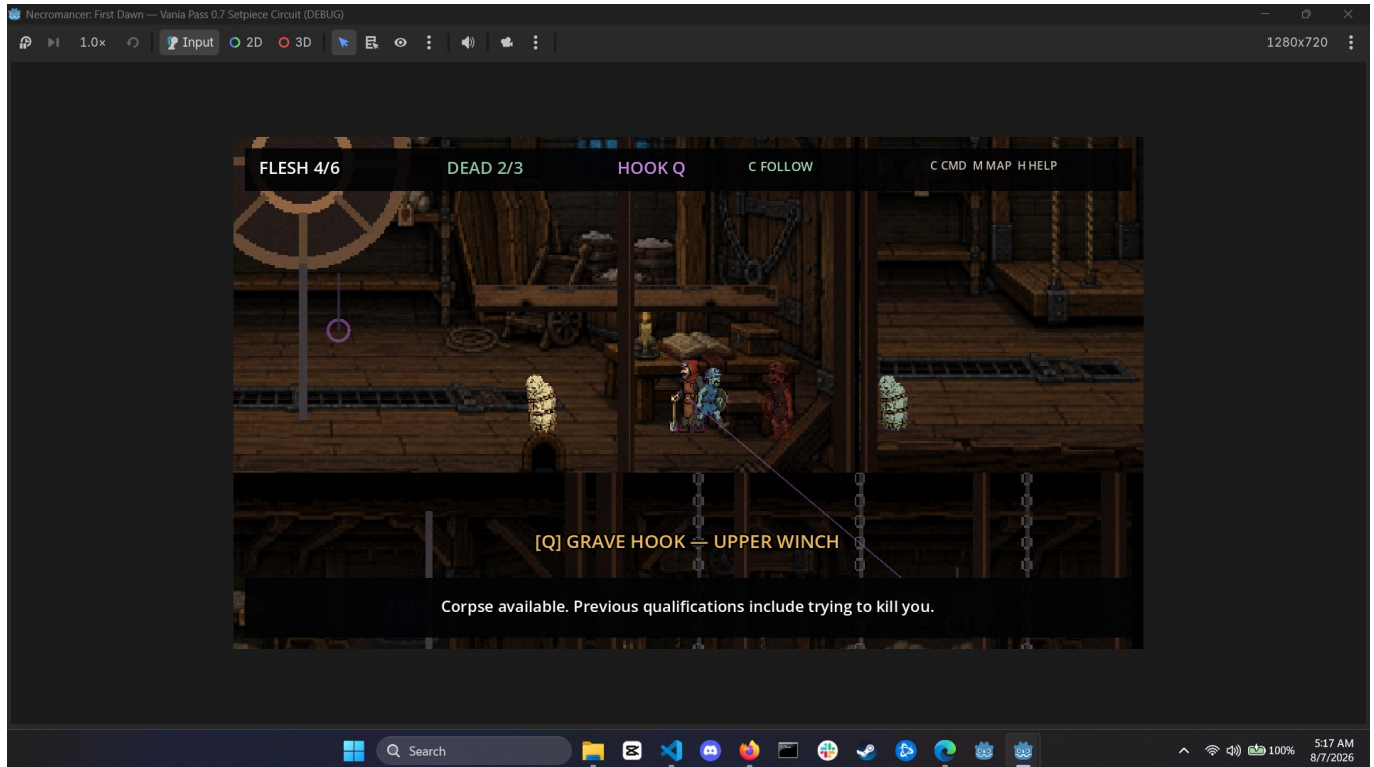


NECROMANCER: FIRST DAWN

Production & Direction Document

Working Draft - Vania Pass 0.9 - August 2026



Current prototype lineage: the Plague Barge has evolved from a mechanics test into an authored room-based action Metroidvania.

**Explore a gothic storybook world. Kill interesting things. Raise the ones you want.
Command your strange little dead party.**

1. Project Summary

Necromancer: First Dawn is the working title for a 2D gothic action Metroidvania centered on a simple but far-reaching fantasy: enemies are not merely obstacles or loot sources; many of them can become members of the player's undead party after death.

The current prototype is set aboard the Plague Barge, a corpse-hauling vessel moving through a damp, crooked, Halloween-storybook world. The first level is being developed as a self-contained vertical slice that teaches movement, combat, charged resurrection, party command, the Grave Hook traversal tool, shortcuts, room-based exploration, and the tone of the world.

Current elevator pitch: A gothic action Metroidvania where every enemy you kill is a potential party member.

Design pillars

- Explore memorable rooms rather than sprinting through a continuous action stage.
- Fight readable, varied enemies with a compact but expressive player moveset.
- Turn enemy composition into party-building decisions through Raise the Dead.
- Command a small undead party without converting the game into an RTS.
- Use necromancy for traversal and environmental interaction, not only damage.
- Balance dark subject matter with chunky, expressive art and dry gallows humor.

Reference stack - what remains and what changed

Reference	Take from it	Do not inherit
Bloodstained / Castlevania: Order of Ecclesia	Room traversal, doors, authored gothic spaces, ability-gated revisits, map language.	Exact art, music, lore, or mechanical copying.
Rogue Legacy	Readable enemy archetypes, fast response, attack variance, punish windows.	Run structure as the primary identity or excessive procedural-room feel.
Ghosts 'n Goblins	Macabre adventure, Halloween charm, theatrical monsters and silhouettes.	Punishing precision platforming as the main challenge.
Metal Slug	Chunky/cartoon expressiveness, immediate animation response, visual personality.	Run-right arcade pacing or constant sensory pressure.
Blasphemous	Proof that 2D gothic worlds can carry weight and atmosphere.	Its oppressive severity and highly specific religious-grotesque identity.

2. Development History & What Each Stage Taught Us

Stage	What existed	What worked	What changed next
Cargo Hold test	Single procedural room; basic movement, attack and resurrection.	The core idea was immediately understandable and movement could feel lively.	Stop treating it as a test room; build a level and preserve the responsive feel.
Early Vania pass 0.4-0.5	Connected screens, first Grave Hook, map, enemy archetypes.	Exploration and upgrades made the concept more game-like.	Room scale, collision reliability, message pacing and traversal logic needed major work.
Combat & Command 0.6	Three-hit combo, hit-stop, follower roles, Follow/Hold/Assault, smarter enemy states.	Combat became noticeably more fun; followers became part of the fantasy.	Collision seams and monolithic world architecture were fighting every system.
Setpiece circuit 0.7	Larger Plague Barge route, Rib Gate loop, Hull Breach idea, wider deck finale.	The first level developed a recognizable authored rhythm.	A giant continuous coordinate space caused Hook, seam, camera and AI problems.
Room-scene refactor 0.8	Independent Godot .tscn rooms, explicit doors/hatches, local encounters and Hook anchors.	Correct technical foundation for Castlevania/Bloodstained traversal.	Now deepen Raise, command intelligence, directional Hook use, art layering and world size.
Raise & Command 0.9	Charged Raise ritual, directional Grave Field, combat specials, direct army orders, 14-room barge route.	Current target: make necromancy itself the signature loop rather than a side mechanic.	Playtest, polish, improve art individuality and build the first complete vertical slice.



0.8 established the room-scene architecture: individual compartments, explicit boundaries and room-local systems.

3. Core Game Loop

The intended moment-to-moment loop is built around exploration, readable combat and party composition rather than speed-clearing rooms.

Enter / read the room: Understand its geometry, enemies, obvious exits, suspicious inaccessible spaces and environmental story.

Fight: Use the three-hit chain, rising cut, aerial plunge, positioning and later spells to create safe openings.

Choose what is worth raising: A dead enemy can be left behind, raised immediately under pressure, or selected because its role solves a future combat or traversal problem.

Command the party: Followers protect, hold, assault, support or interact according to role and player direction.

Explore / unlock: Use doors, shortcuts, the Grave Hook and eventually corpse-specific abilities to recontextualize old rooms.

Return stronger or stranger: Backtracking should feel like possessing new vocabulary rather than merely having a higher damage number.

Player combat - current and intended

- Fast three-hit ground chain with stronger third-hit commitment and payoff.
- Up + Attack: rising anti-air cut for enemies above the player.
- Down + Attack while airborne: plunging strike with bounce on confirmed hit.
- Grave Hook: traversal, light-enemy manipulation and specific environmental interactions.
- Raise the Dead: held, interruptible ritual rather than an instant interaction.
- Future candidates: short backstep/dodge, one equipped necromancy spell, armor-breaking heavy option.

4. Raise the Dead - Signature System

The enemy roster is also the party roster.

Raise should be one of the most satisfying repeated actions in the game. In 0.9, resurrection becomes a charged ritual: the player holds E near a settled corpse while a necromantic ring fills. Larger or more specialized corpses take longer. Movement and offense are constrained during the channel, so attempting a Raise before an encounter is fully safe becomes an intentional risk/reward decision.

Why charged resurrection matters

- It creates anticipation and spectacle around the game's signature action.
- It makes corpse selection a tactical decision during live combat.
- It gives enemy durability and role a second meaning after death.
- It creates upgrade space: faster rituals, larger radius, damaging resurrection burst, empowered first seconds, etc.

Current follower roles

Role	Typical source	Combat intelligence	Future traversal utility
Guard	Walker / Shield Guard	Protects player space; prefers chargers and threatening front-line enemies.	Pressure plates, projectile interception, guard-specific switches.
Brute	Brute / Charger	Prioritizes heavy front-line threats and soaks space.	Break weak walls, hold heavy mechanisms, move obstacles.
Sentry	Sentry / Bell Wretch / Lantern Tosser	Prioritizes ranged/support nuisances and seeks clear firing lanes.	Hit distant switches, ignite targets, support puzzles.

Command philosophy

Commands should feel like a necromancer directing a small gang, not like StarCraft with three idiots. The player issues broad intent and the followers supply competent execution.

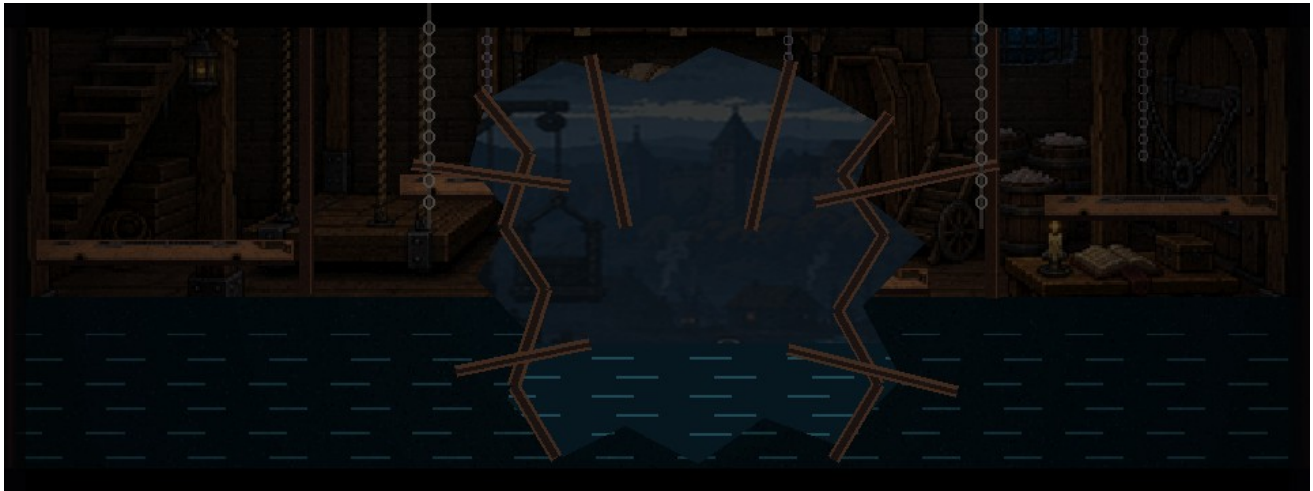
- Tap C: cycle Follow / Hold / Assault posture.
- Up + C: Assault - push the party forward.
- Down + C: Recall - reform around the necromancer.
- Left or Right + C: Hold There - establish a nearby defended point on valid ground.
- Future: context highlighting for winches, plates, high switches and role-specific interactions.
- Later ability candidate: temporary possession of one raised corpse for special traversal or puzzle spaces.

5. Grave Hook - Occult Traversal, Not a Grapple Gun

The original Hook automatically selected nearby anchors and pulled directly to authored landing points. This became frustrating when anchors were close together and occasionally made the ability feel technological rather than necromantic.

The 0.9 direction borrows the useful principle of Order of Ecclesia's Magnes without reproducing it: holding Q opens a local Grave Field around the player. Valid room-local anchors awaken. WASD / arrow input indicates direction. Releasing Q commits to the selected anchor. Directional alignment scores more heavily than simple proximity, so adjacent rings no longer steal selection from one another.

- Indoor radius remains intentionally local to the current compartment.
- One available anchor is automatically forgiving; several anchors require directional intent.
- The Hook can still tear the Rib Gate and drag susceptible light enemies.
- Long, dramatic pulls are reserved for future outdoor stages where the geography supports them.



The Hull Breach reframed the old “water room” as environmental damage to the barge: traversal emerges from the set piece instead of abstract platforms over a pool.

6. Level & Room Design Philosophy

The Plague Barge is now treated as a collection of compartments rather than a miniature open world. Each room is an authored Godot scene with explicit doors or hatches, local encounters, collision, camera bounds, Hook anchors, spawn markers and 2-3 visual layers.

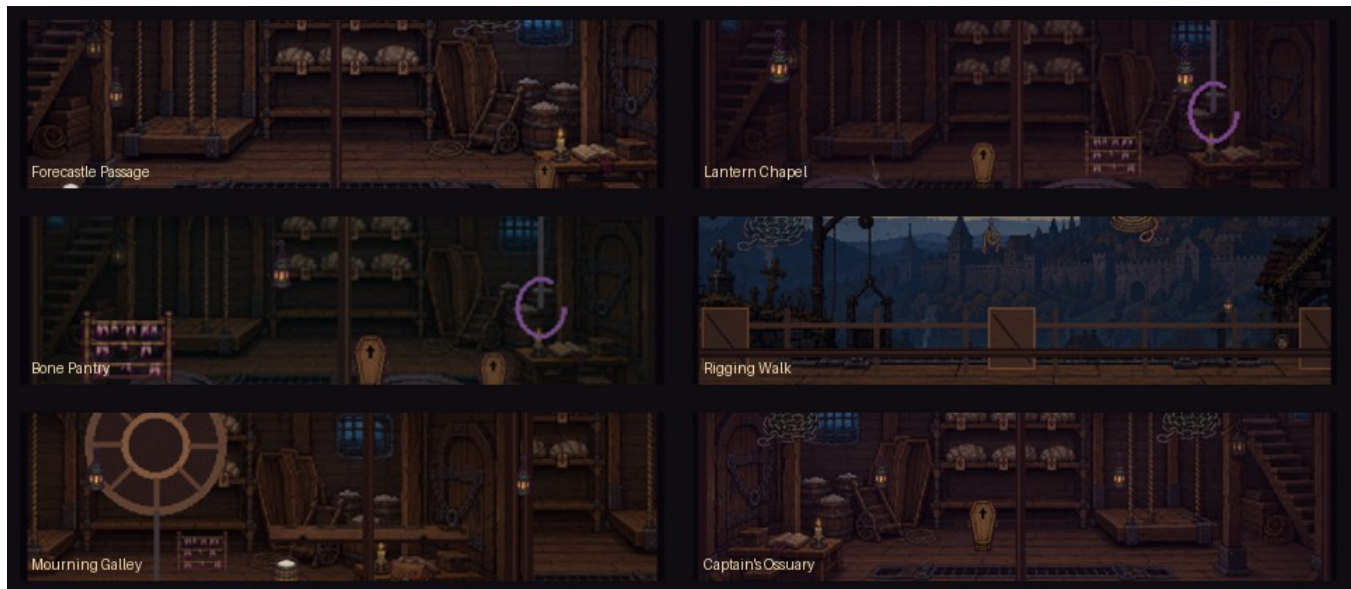
Traversal rules

- Normal routes use broad landings and visibly plausible jumps.
- If a nearby ledge looks jumpable, it should usually be jumpable.
- Ability-gated geometry must read differently enough that failure feels intentional, not like a collision bug.
- Precision platforming is seasoning, not the core difficulty model.
- Doors open, the player crosses the threshold, the adjacent room loads, and the party reforms at the matching entrance.
- Room transitions are mostly seamless and player-controlled; brief camera direction is reserved for discrete points of interest or set-piece punctuation.

0.9 Plague Barge route - 14 compartments

Receiving Hold -> Forecastle Passage -> Lantern Chapel -> Quarantine Gallery -> Rib Gate -> Hull Breach -> Bone Pantry -> Chain Crypt -> Winch Shaft -> Upper Orlop -> Rigging Walk -> Mourning Galley -> Captain's Ossuary -> Ossuary Deck

The Rib Gate remains the important loop: it is encountered before the Grave Hook, forces the lower route, then opens from the far side after the player acquires the Hook. This is the first deliberate Metroidvania “see obstacle -> learn world -> gain vocabulary -> return -> shortcut” beat.



Six additional 0.9 compartments move the visual vocabulary toward crooked timber, orange lanterns, violet night, coffins, chains and storybook maritime horror.

7. Art, Tone & Presentation Direction

Dark subject matter; expressive, spooky, adventurous presentation.

The project is moving away from Blasphemous as a dominant aesthetic reference. Its severity helped establish atmosphere, but the game's own personality is stronger when the macabre world is allowed to be colorful, theatrical and occasionally delightful.

Visual vocabulary

- Cartoony, chunky, highly readable character sprites remain a strength.
- Crooked grave markers, wrought iron, pointy roofs, enormous coffins, gargoyles, twisted ship ribs and old cemetery statuary.
- Purple / blue night, sickly corpse greens, warm pumpkin-orange lanterns, fog and candlelight.
- Timber, iron, bone, wet cloth and moonlit water as the dominant Plague Barge materials.
- 2-3 organized render layers per room: far/background atmosphere, gameplay architecture, selective foreground occlusion.
- Characters should receive subtle environmental grounding: contact shadow, room tint, surface particles and occasional foreground overlap.

Tone and humor

The world can take death, plague and necromancy seriously without every line becoming solemn. Humor works best as dry release after a dramatic or mechanical beat, not as a constant commentary track. The prototype's recurring "employment / management" jokes are useful because they arise naturally from forcing dead enemies into a party.

- Keep jokes sparse enough to land.
- Let animation and follower behavior carry some humor without text.
- Messages use a deliberate gap and a single waiting slot rather than arriving back-to-back.
- Serious worldbuilding moments should be allowed to remain serious.

8. Enemy Design Philosophy

Enemy intelligence should resemble readable roguelite combat rather than brute-force homing. Every archetype needs a job, a tell, a committed action and a recovery window. Smarter does not mean unpredictable; it means choosing a sensible action for the current geometry and encounter composition.

Archetype	Enemy job	Readable behavior	Raised value
Walker	Baseline melee	Patrol -> approach -> telegraphed swing -> recovery.	Guard
Charger	Lane pressure	Creates space, verifies floor lane, commits to charge, long punish window.	Brute
Sentry	Ranged control	Maintains distance and fires only with line of sight.	Sentry
Hopper	Vertical disruption	Predicts movement, verifies landing, commits to an arc.	Guard
Brute	Space / armor	Slow wide strike, poise vs light hits, vulnerable after commitment.	Brute
Bell Wretch	Support priority	Alerts / accelerates allies; weak if isolated.	Sentry support
Shield Guard - 0.9	Front-line defense	Blocks light frontal attacks; heavy/plunge or rear attack breaks the assumption.	Guard
Lantern Tossler - 0.9	Mid-range harassment	Repositions and throws slower projectiles from a preferred lane.	Sentry

Encounter design target

A good room should make the player read a composition - for example, a Shield Guard holding the floor while a Lantern Tossler occupies a back platform and a Bell Wretch makes both more dangerous. The player is then simultaneously choosing a combat solution and deciding which corpse might be worth recruiting afterward.

9. Technical Architecture

- Engine: Godot 4.x project; current prototype lineage developed against Godot 4.7-era APIs/settings.
- World structure: independent room scenes under `res://scenes/` barge/.
- Persistent manager: player, army state, UI, combat feedback, map, progression and room transitions.
- Room ownership: collisions, doors, spawn points, enemy encounter markers, Hook anchors, camera profile and environmental layers.
- GameState persists health, army roles, command posture, Grave Hook state, Rib Gate shortcut, checkpoint, map discovery and upgrades.
- Static Python audits are shipped with builds to validate resource references, room graph, target spawns, jump envelopes, script structure and major feature contracts.

Why the 0.8 refactor mattered

The earlier giant-world prototype encoded room art, collisions, Hook targets, enemy spawns and progression inside one enormous coordinate space. That created seam collisions, accidental cross-room Hook pulls, off-screen AI problems and difficult debugging. Converting each compartment into its own scene is an upfront cost that substantially reduces future collision whack-a-mole and makes room art replaceable one room at a time.

Audio direction

Prototype SFX currently cover swings, impacts, hurt, Raise, Hook, commands, alerts, relic fanfare and doors. A private local reference-music slot exists for studying pacing; copyrighted reference material is not intended for distribution. Final music should be original and evoke damp gothic adventure, haunted water, bells, strings/harpsichord-like color and memorable melodic movement rather than copying any Castlevania composition.

10. Production Roadmap

Milestone	Primary goal	Exit criteria	Status
0.9 - Raise & Command	Make necromancy the signature loop and grow the Barge.	Charged Raise feels good; directional Hook selects predictably; direct commands are useful; 14-room graph is traversable.	Current build
0.10 - Art & Encounter Pass	Make rooms visually distinct and encounters authored.	More layered rooms, reduced placeholder repetition, enemy compositions teach party choices, collision sweep passes.	Next
0.11 - Party Utility Pass	Turn follower roles into exploration tools.	At least three corpse-role environmental interactions; party command UI remains simple.	Planned
1.0 Vertical Slice	A complete first-level experience suitable for outside playtesting.	Polished Plague Barge route, boss/set piece, checkpoint/save behavior, audio pass, stable collisions, clear progression, onboarding.	Target
Post-slice	Prove the larger game structure.	Second biome, expanded ability vocabulary, progression framework, content pipeline and production scope established.	Future

Definition of a successful first level

- A new player can traverse the entire Plague Barge without collision confusion or external explanation.
- The player encounters the Rib Gate before the Grave Hook and understands the shortcut payoff later.
- At least once, the player sees an enemy and thinks, “I want that one in my party.”
- Raised followers feel useful and characterful rather than like damage particles following the player.
- Combat asks for more than repeating the basic attack.
- The Hull Breach, Gallery, Rigging and final Deck each read as visually distinct set pieces.
- The tone is spooky, adventurous and macabre without becoming relentlessly grim.

11. Known Risks & Open Design Questions

Collision / traversal trust: This has historically been the prototype's largest usability problem. Every room must be validated against the actual player jump envelope and visible surfaces. Debug collision overlay remains a development tool, not a substitute for coherent authored geometry.

Follower competence: Followers must be helpful without solving every encounter automatically. Navigation recovery should be invisible or diegetic, not frequent teleportation.

Party composition depth vs friction: Three slots are readable now. Future role complexity must not make corpse management feel like inventory housekeeping.

Hook complexity: The Grave Field should improve directional intent without freezing play too often or becoming a second cursor-control game.

Message / humor density: Good jokes lose value when delivered every few seconds. Flavor should increasingly move into animation, room dressing and enemy/follower behavior.

Art pipeline: Existing backgrounds are effective prototype paintings but many remain flattened. The room-scene architecture now supports gradual conversion to clean 2-3 layer compositions.

Scope: The resurrection system can support enormous feature breadth. Production should prioritize a small number of deeply integrated corpse roles before adding dozens of shallow enemy types.

North star: the player should feel like they are exploring a strange gothic storybook with a hand-picked gang of former enemies at their heels.